

Kenya Conflict Analysis

MAIN ACTORS

Al-Shabaab and Al-Hijra	Exploitation of marginalisation and youth unemployment driving recruitment and destabilisation, primarily along the Kenya-Somalia border and in Nairobi.
Communal militias	Persistent activity along ethnic and clan lines driving pastoralist and resource conflicts across northern and eastern counties, enabled by small arms proliferation.
Security forces	Documented corruption and heavy-handed operations deepening community grievances.
Political elites	Competition for political office and resource allocation intensifying along ethnic and clan lines, particularly around elections.

REGIONS WITH STRONG PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

SEPI RANKINGS — STRONG PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

#	Region	SEPI	Education	Health Access	Food Security	Poverty Reduction	Climate	Events /100k
1	Kisumu	0.672	0.568	0.719	1.000	0.549	0.609	0
2	Nyeri	0.654	0.705	0.835	0.833	0.615	0.397	0
3	Vihiga	0.648	0.692	0.473	1.000	0.463	0.754	0
4	Kisii	0.629	0.567	0.654	1.000	0.434	0.612	1
5	Tharaka-Nithi	0.624	0.559	0.754	1.000	0.449	0.500	0

Higher SEPI score counties cluster in two zones: western Kenya (Kisumu, Vihiga, Kisii, Nyamira, Kakamega, Siaya, Homa Bay, Migori) and the Mt. Kenya highlands (Nyeri, Tharaka-Nithi, Embu, Kirinyaga, Murang'a). Both zones share high-rainfall agriculture, near-zero IPC monitoring, and very low conflict intensity.

REGIONS WITH WEAK PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

SEPI RANKINGS — WEAK PEACEBUILDING CAPACITY

#	Region	SEPI	Education	Health Access	Food Security	Poverty Reduction	Climate	Events /100k
47	Mandera	0.029	0.510	0.046	0.000	0.000	0.000	5
46	Turkana	0.234	0.397	0.166	0.333	0.060	0.530	4

#	Region	SEPI	Education	Health Access	Food Security	Poverty Reduction	Climate	Events /100k
45	Tana River	0.297	0.328	0.223	0.500	0.120	0.527	2
44	Samburu	0.301	0.298	0.235	0.667	0.096	0.549	9
43	West Pokot	0.318	0.408	0.230	0.833	0.146	0.284	1

Mandera is a severe outlier: all pillars except education collapse — food security 0.000 (active IPC crisis), economic 0.000 (extreme poverty), health 0.046.

The 10 counties with the lowest SEPI scores are all in the arid/semi-arid north and northeast; a geographic concentration suggesting structural rather than county-specific factors.

SOURCES OF RESILIENCE

The establishment of county-level administrations has expanded the state-building process into previously marginalised areas, with devolved funds enabling greater local service delivery and conflict mitigation capacity. In 2023, a multi-agency operation — Operation Maliza Uhalifu — was launched across the North Rift counties combining the Kenya Defence Forces and National Police Service to restore security and support voluntary disarmament across Elgeyo Marakwet, Baringo, Turkana, Samburu, and West Pokot counties.